

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Lost outdoors

FIELD SKILLS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Stop moving, stay together and assess your last known position. If there is no immediate threat, stay put, protect yourself from weather and signal for help. Share your location if communication works; do not wander in search of a shortcut.

Do now.

- ☐ **Stop and assess**
01 Check injury, weather, daylight and remaining supplies. Mark your location and the last reliable landmark on an offline map if available.
- ☐ **Choose a safe waiting place**
02 Move only enough to escape immediate hazards such as floodwater, falling trees or exposed severe weather. Keep the group together and tell contacts if your location changes.
- ☐ **Protect from exposure**
03 Use available layers and shelter to reduce wet, wind, cold or sun exposure. Avoid hazardous terrain while trying to improve a shelter.
- ☐ **Signal and conserve**
04 Use a whistle, bright material or light when appropriate. Call or send a location message if possible; conserve phone power between attempts.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use the supplies and shelter you already have; do not assume a rescue is underway until communication confirms it. Leave a clear note of time, direction and destination only if immediate danger forces a move. Avoid dividing the party or attempting unverified routes in darkness.

Watch for.

A phone compass or GPS reading is not a safe route by itself. Do not climb hazardous ridges for a signal or enter moving water.

People & practical needs.

Keep children and less mobile companions beside an adult. Check everyone for cold, heat and exhaustion and inventory each person's supplies

Next decision.

Give rescuers coordinates, last known location, group size, injuries and equipment. When a location is shared, stay there unless a direct threat forces a move.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

INCIDENT / SYMPTOM ONSET / LOCATION

HELP REQUESTED / RESPONSE CONFIRMED

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

NPS - Outdoor emergency plan

NPS - Hiking safety

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/guides/lost-outdoors/>